



New recruits: Bayern Munich has strengthened its squad by signing Morocco's World Cup star Ismael Saibari (in pic), along with German full-back Nathaniel Brown. REUTERS

anticipation, tackling skills and technique. When he hung up his boots in 1997, his number 6 shirt was retired, making him the first player in Milan's history to earn that honour.

Bundesliga and Ligue 1

While the rest of Europe's top leagues provide some sense of unpredictability and anticipation, Germany and France have had a strikingly similar hegemony.

For Bayern Munich and European champion Paris Saint-Germain, anything short of the title seems a failure at this point. The Bavarians found the back of the net a record 122 times and lost just once in the entire league campaign to lift their 34th Bundesliga title.

Despite speculation that several of its stars, including Michael Olise and Luis Diaz, could seek a move away from the club, none of it has turned out to be true so far. In fact, Bayern has reinforced its squad even

further, signing Morocco's World Cup star Ismael Saibari and young full-back Nathaniel Brown. Teams like Borussia Dortmund, RB Leipzig, and Bayer Leverkusen can only hope to keep pace with Bayern and wait to strike if and when it drops its standards.

Meanwhile, across the border, PSG was made to toil a bit more to secure its record 14th title, but its plethora of talent, along with the tactical brain of Luis Enrique on the sidelines, means that it can get any job done.

Moreover, its financial

Contrastingly, traditional giants Juventus and AC Milan have been busy identifying individuals who can help them restore their status after missing out on Champions League football. Record league winner Juventus boosted its attack with Frenchman Randal Kolo Muani and Bosnia's Kerim Alajbegovic, while Milan secured the services of Portuguese striker Goncalo Ramos as it begins life under new manager Ruben Amorim, who is back since being sacked by Manchester United in January.

Milan will be playing with an added weight on its shoulders, carrying the memory of legendary defender Franco Baresi, who passed away on July 31 aged 66.

Baresi captained Milan in the 1980s and 90s, during which it won three European Cups and six Italian league titles, and despite his comparatively diminutive stature, he was widely praised for his



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No time to waste

The World Cup introduced some new rules, which, though initially met with mixed opinions, eventually spoiled fans with a flowing tempo and quick restarts.

Noticing the response, several leagues have adopted these changes, forcing the players to be on their toes at all times.

Fans will now see their players getting just 10 seconds to get off the pitch after being subbed, or risk leaving the team to play with just 10 men for a minute.

Meanwhile, a similar scenario can arise if a player receives treatment on the pitch, which will require them to stay on the sidelines for 60 seconds before being called back into play. Goal kicks and throw-ins will need to be taken within five seconds, and a failure to do so will result in the opposition getting a corner or throw-in, respectively. While supporters and viewers will be stripped of the hallowed 'dark arts' of football, these changes are sure to grow on them just like they did over the summer in North America.

backing has helped it rope in winger Maghnes Akliouche (**left**) from Monaco after the 24-year-old impressed during the clubs' meetings in the Champions League playoffs.

It has also added experience to its back line by signing full-back Lucas Digne from Aston Villa. And with reports suggesting that Ferran Torres could join an attack featuring Ousmane Dembele, Desire Doue, Khvicha Kvaratskhelia and more, it seems unlikely any team will depose the French giant.